

SEYI MAKINDE ANNUAL ESSAY COMPETITION 2022

TOPIC

ADVANCING THE FRONTIERS OF POSSIBILITIES FOR A SAFE, SECURED
AND PROSPEROUS OYO STATE THROUGH CITIZEN'S ACTIVE
PARTICIPATION IN GOVERNANCE PROCESSES

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Introduction

For the past three years of Governor Seyi Makinde in office, Oyo state has been setting the pace in different areas for other states in Nigeria. The Makinde-led administration prioritizes Education, Security, Healthcare, and Economy—through agribusiness—as the four pillars of the government and impetus to drive through the 2019-2023 Oyo state roadmap for accelerated development, leaving no stone unturned. As the administration promised the people of Oyo state, the development plan has taken a catalyzed acceleration so fast that it has gone 50% halfway within the 12 months of the governor in office and 75% overall manifesto completion with overshoot in some areas.¹ However, Oyo state citizens, young and old, should also be part of this development plan to expand the borderline for immeasurable possibilities in building a safer, more secure, and prosperous Oyo state. Therefore, this essay will discuss different ways citizens can uphold the four pillars of the government to create a greater state and the need for us as a citizenry to take part in the governance process.

Education

Undoubtedly, Education is the most powerful weapon to change the world, as Nelson Mandela said. The Oyo state government has been trending this path through the construction of 56 model schools across the state,² adding to over 300 completed projects and other achievements of the administration in the education sector only.³ Regarding this, students should utilize the provided facilities and opportunities to improve their knowledge and explore different innovative skills that can further spur the development of Oyo state in Science and Technology.

Moreover, educated citizens should give the state government a hand by researching the different social phenomena that can affect the livelihoods of Oyo state citizens. It could be the effects of climate change, energy transition, environmental pollution, or the rate of truancy among public school students in Oyo state. The latter will give the government more insight and directions on which schools to focus on to continue revitalizing Education in Oyo state. It also brings about the disciplinary committee to deter wayward students, as commonly seen in public schools, from constituting a nuisance in society.

Security

In recent times, Oyo state has witnessed different security challenges ranging from kidnapping, armed robbery, tribal conflicts, and killing in places like Oke-Ogun, Ibarapa, Igboho, and Ibadan.⁴ Nevertheless, the government is relentless and taking tremendous measures to extinguish the fire of insecurity in the state. Governor Seyi Makinde-led administration has emplaced and re-strengthened different security operations like the ‘Amotekun’, Police Swift Response (SRS), and Police Mobile Force (PMF) Squadron across the state.⁵

To be part of this fight, citizens in different communities must form pressure groups to swat the fly of insecurity looming in our society. Communities should enhance regional security levels and enjoin people to participate in vigilante schemes to reinforce neighborhood safety. Funds should be pooled together to erect community structures like a fence, lamp posts in some dangerous spots, and iron gates at different entrances of the community. As a result, participatory interventions like these will not only protect the lives and properties of the people in the community but also ensure

a peaceful environment for the residents. On the other hand, they will serve as helping tools for state security agencies.

Healthcare

Health is wealth, they say, but its meaning hit harder on the sick bed. Good health is a vital part of human life just like the adequate provision of healthcare facilities for the citizens is a crucial requirement for a society to prosper. In light of this, many healthcare projects have been implemented while other interventions are in progress in Oyo state. These include; rehabilitating and quipping hospitals, free surgeries and medical care for the people, creating a linkage framework for partnership, and many more.⁶ Furthermore, Governor Seyi has put it in the plan to install healthcare in rural areas as well, to serve as a blanket invention in healthcare throughout the state.⁷

In addition, the citizens, as groups or organizations, can contribute to these healthcare developments by raising community awareness and educating people on the importance of medical checkups and taking preventive measures for some diseases. Who knows should tell who knows not, and who knows not should seek after who knows for help. Recent studies have shown a low level of awareness of Oyo state citizens in different diseases like breast cancer, the most common female cancer,⁸ and in health services like adolescent reproductive health services (ARHSs) among in-school adolescents.⁹

Agribusiness

Agriculture is now regarded as the new oil in Nigeria, and the state government has been leveraging it to boost its economy and generate internal revenue for the state. In the past three

years, Governor Seyi Makinde-led administration has implemented and invested enormously in agriculture through the construction of roads for rural areas access, establishment, and expansion of Agricultural centers and schools for youths, and collaboration with private sectors, the federal government, and international organization for funds and support.¹⁰

These achievements, however, have opened different doors of opportunities for citizens who are exploiting agriculture. This year, increased private sector participation in agriculture made Oyo state generate N23 billion in agribusiness investments, and about 4,050 youths have been trained, where 98 of them have started their agribusinesses.¹¹ Therefore, the citizens, especially the youths, should see agriculture not as a labor-ridden practice but as a driver for the state from poverty to prosperity. We must all participate in the development programs in agribusiness and utilize the opportunities made available to improve agriculture in Oyo state.

Conclusion

Indeed, we are a pacesetter in Oyo state, and God has given us a leadership position. It has been established that citizen participatory impacts on the Oyo state governance process cannot be overemphasized. We must realize that one man, one voice, and one action can bring a profound change in the state and the lives of the people nestling in it. It also portends a better country and prosperous future for the coming generations. The earlier we realize these things, the better.

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